

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN LEBANON

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action decides project outcomes in Lebanon, and a green valley south of Beirut proved it against the government and the World Bank at once. In the **Bisri Valley**, the state and the Bank planned a mega-dam that would have drowned six million square metres of fertile land — pine and citrus groves that had cradled civilisations since the Bronze Age — and more than fifty historical and archaeological sites, among them a Roman temple and the Mar Moussa Church, all on an active seismic fault. The valley was no empty ground: six million square metres of pine and citrus and fertile earth that had held human settlement since the Bronze Age, threaded with ruins and shrines, and the assurances that a dam and its reservoir on an active fault would not raise the risk of earthquakes rested on a safety assessment that had not been updated in years. To Lebanese eyes it was a place of heritage, livelihood, and beauty being offered up, on a fault line, to a project of doubtful need and evident profit. The political class backed it; a World Bank loan funded it. But Lebanese people would not accept it. The **Save the Bisri Valley** campaign — the National Campaign to Protect the Bisri Valley together with the **Lebanon Eco Movement** — petitioned the World Bank to cancel the dam, documented the harm to the valley, the heritage, and the safety, occupied the valley when the bulldozers came, and tied their fight to the country's wider uprising against a corrupt and collapsing state. When the bankrupt government failed to meet the Bank's own preconditions, the **World Bank cancelled its remaining funds in September 2020**, and the dam died. A campaign of citizens had stopped a mega-project the whole political establishment wanted, by turning the project's own financier against it. The particulars are worth setting down, because they are the lessons. The dam, part of a Greater Beirut water-supply scheme, sat about thirty kilometres south of the capital, and the World Bank had agreed in 2014 to co-finance it with a loan of some four hundred and seventy-four million dollars, alongside the Islamic Development Bank and the Lebanese state. Construction, due for completion in 2024, never began; the contractor was never even mobilised. From early 2020 the Bank repeatedly raised concerns; in June it partially suspended the loan and gave the government until early September to meet the preconditions to construction — an ecological compensation plan, operations arrangements, genuine consultation. The bankrupt government did not meet them, and on the fourth of September 2020 the Bank cancelled the two hundred and forty-four million dollars that remained. The campaigners had not needed to win in a Lebanese court; they had needed to hold the financier to its own rules, and let a collapsing state fail its conditions.

The Bisri fight teaches two things about winning in Lebanon — including its hard limits, which this guide will not hide. The first is the pattern: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected community, the environmental movement, the heritage and the seismic danger, the international financier, the corruption exposed, and the street — pressed together until the loan was cancelled. The second is distinctly Lebanese, and hard-won. **When your own state is captured, broke, and cannot be trusted to decide fairly, the most powerful lever is often the international financier and its own rules** — the World Bank's safeguards, its preconditions, its promises on climate and participation, which a campaign can hold it to. This is a hard-won and slightly bitter lesson, and worth stating plainly: in a country where the government, the ministries, and often the courts serve the project, the body most likely to stop it may be a foreign bank in Washington, precisely because that bank answers to environmental and social safeguards, to preconditions written into its loan, and to a reputation it must protect — none of which the Lebanese state feels bound by. A campaign that grasps this stops wasting its strength petitioning a captured state and aims instead at the financier, whose rules it can actually invoke. That, together with **direct action** in the place itself, the **heritage and seismic-safety** arguments, and the fight woven into the broader struggle against **corruption**, gives communities here a real and distinctive power — even against the entire political class.

But the same story carries honest warnings, and this guide states them plainly, because Lebanon's context is among the hardest anywhere. The Bisri win leaned heavily on the **World Bank's own process and on Lebanon's collapse** — the government, amid sovereign default and currency ruin, simply failed to meet the Bank's conditions, and a functioning state might have met them. The win was **defensive**: it stopped a bad dam but did not solve the real water shortage the dam was sold to fix, and campaigners had to argue for the alternatives. This is a limit worth naming honestly, because a proponent will use it against you: stopping a project framed as the answer to a real need — water for a thirsty city, in Bisri's case — invites the charge that you offer nothing in its place. The Bisri campaigners met it by arguing for the alternatives the establishment had ignored, from fixing the vast leaks in the existing network to smaller, safer schemes, and a Lebanese campaign is stronger when it can point past the bad project to the better answer the corrupt version was designed to crowd out. Above all, the **state itself is captured, sectarian, and broken** — domestic institutions cannot be relied on, enforcement is weak, and the win came despite the Lebanese state, not through it. And the wider 2019

uprising, for all its force, did not remake the political system. This guide is written with both truths in view: the real, distinctive power of a Lebanese public that targets the financier and the corruption behind a project, and the collapsed, captured state that makes every fight here an uphill one.

Most communities do not know HOW to make opposition effective. They discover a project already approved by the political class, assume "the zaims and the donors have decided," and never petition the financier, never document the heritage or the seismic danger, never occupy the site, never tie the fight to the anti-corruption cause, never build the coalition. They generate private despair without a public campaign. The gap between a community that stops a project and one that watches it get built is rarely courage — Lebanese have courage to spare. It is method: knowing that the lever a captured state denies you may still be found in the financier, the street, the heritage, and the corruption laid bare.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the Lebanese system as it is.

The Strategic Framework

Effective opposition campaigns follow the same underlying pattern, whichever project they face:

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STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION (find the decision, the financier, and the weak point)
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STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION        (build proof of harm, danger, and corruption)
      |
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION      (build the coalition and take the valley)
      |
STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES      (the financier's rules, the courts, and the record)
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STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY        (make it national and international)
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These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. Documentation feeds the petition to the financier and the public argument at once; the coalition sustains the pressure and the occupation; a letter to the World Bank is a headline and a headline builds the movement. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, is the one that wins. The Bisri campaign did exactly this — it documented the valley, the heritage, and the danger, petitioned the financier, occupied the site, exposed the corruption, and carried the argument to the nation and the world, until the loan was cancelled.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Lebanon's give communities a distinctive set — precisely because the state is so weak:

- **The international financier and its rules.** Many big projects depend on a foreign loan — the World Bank, other development banks — bound by their own safeguards, preconditions, and public commitments. Holding the financier to its own rules, as at Bisri, can kill a project the state would never stop. The mechanics matter: a development bank typically attaches conditions to its loan — an environmental plan, a consultation process, operating arrangements — that must be satisfied before construction may begin, and it usually operates a formal accountability or complaint mechanism open to affected people. Each of these is a place a campaign can press, and each is governed by rules the bank cannot be seen to ignore. At Bisri the decisive fact was simply that the preconditions went unmet; a campaign that keeps the pressure on those preconditions, and files to the complaint mechanism, works with the grain of the financier's own process.
- **Direct action in the place.** Occupying the site, camping in the valley, and physically stalling the works, as Bisri's defenders did, buys time and rouses the nation.
- **Heritage and seismic safety.** Lebanon's land is dense with archaeology and lies in an earthquake zone, so the threat to heritage and the danger of a project on a fault are powerful, distinctive arguments.
- **The anti-corruption cause.** A destructive project is often also a corruption vehicle for the political class; tying the fight to the wider struggle against corruption, as the 2019 uprising did, multiplies its force. The Bisri dam belonged to a programme of some fourteen dams that critics long described as a rent-seeking scheme for the political class rather than a serious answer to Lebanon's water needs, and campaigners pointedly asked how a bankrupt state, freshly defaulted on its debts, could justify borrowing millions more for such a project. Framing the dam this way — not merely as an environmental harm but as one more theft by the class that had ruined the country — fused the fight with the anger of the 2019 uprising and gave it a national resonance no purely ecological argument could have reached.
- **The street and civil society.** A mobilised public and a vigorous civil society and press are, in a captured state, the levers that still work.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers always prevail. The financier lever depends on there being a **foreign loan**

to cancel, and on the state failing its conditions — not always the case. The win is often **defensive**, stopping a project without solving the need it claimed to meet. The **state is captured and broken**, so domestic institutions rarely help and enforcement is weak. And the sectarian system resists the cross-sectarian unity a campaign needs. This guide takes those limits seriously, names them plainly, and shows you how to fight anyway — targeting the financier and its rules, taking the valley, invoking the heritage and the danger, exposing the corruption, and building the broad public that, at Bisri, stopped the whole establishment.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single weekend, map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and where along that path the decision is weakest — remembering that in Lebanon the weakest point is often not in the state at all.

The Levels of Decision

A Lebanese development project runs through several tracks at once, and each is a place to intervene.

The financier. Large projects depend on **foreign financing** — the World Bank, other development banks, donor states — each bound by its own environmental and social **safeguards, preconditions, and complaint mechanisms**. This is the level at which Bisri was stopped, and often the most reachable. It is worth understanding why it is so reachable when the state is not. A development bank operates at arm's length from Lebanese politics; it publishes its safeguard policies; it writes conditions into its loans; and it fears the reputational damage of being seen to fund a destructive or corrupt project. All of that gives a community points of leverage that simply do not exist with a captured ministry, and it is why a Lebanese campaign should map the financier and its rules before anything else.

The government and the political class. The **cabinet, the ministries, and the parties** approve and push projects — but the political class is captured and clientelist, so this level is usually the proponent, not an ally.

The permits and assessments. Projects need **permits and environmental assessments**, in principle administered by the environment ministry — but the process is weak, and assessments are often old, thin, or ignored, which is itself a vulnerability.

The courts. The **courts** can review decisions, but they are slow, politically entangled, and unreliable, so treat them as one front among several.

The street and civil society. In a captured state, the **public — the protests, the occupations, the civil-society campaigns** — is often the decisive force, as it was at Bisri and in the 2019 uprising.

The Journey of a Project

A typical project moves from approval by the political class, into its **foreign financing**, through weak **permits and assessments**, toward construction — with the **public and civil society** able to petition the financier, occupy the site, and rouse the nation at any point. **Every one of those stages is a door you can put your foot in.** The widest door here is unusual: the **financier**, which answers to rules and reputations the Lebanese state does not. The **occupation of the site** and the **exposure of the corruption** are others. The courts and the ministries are the least reliable doors. Find out exactly where your project stands — and, above all, **who is financing it**, because that is often the key.

Follow the Money, the Fault, and the Heritage

Behind the project stand a proponent — usually the state and a politically connected contractor — its **foreign financier**, and the officials, often corrupt, who pushed it. Trace who profits, who approved it, and — critically in Lebanon — **who is financing it and under what rules, what it destroys of the heritage and the fertile land, and whether it endangers safety, as a dam on a seismic fault does.** Two questions unlock most Lebanese fights: **Who is the foreign financier, and what are its own rules and preconditions?** and **What does the project destroy or endanger — the heritage, the land, the safety — and what corruption drives it?** The financier's rules and the harm-and-corruption are, together, the heart of most Lebanese campaigns. The two reinforce each other in a specific way: the harm, the heritage, and above all the corruption are what make a project a reputational liability the financier wants to be rid of, while the financier's own rules and unmet preconditions are the formal mechanism through which it can actually walk away. A campaign that documents both — the rot that makes the bank want out, and the broken conditions that let it — hands the financier both the motive and the means to cancel.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies that watch the deciders, because they are levers too — and in Lebanon the most useful overseers are outside the state. The **financiers' own accountability and complaint mechanisms**; the **international community and press**, sensitive to a bank funding a destructive, corrupt project; the **civil-society networks and independent media** that document and expose; and the **mobilised public**, the ultimate overseer, which at Bisri stopped the establishment. The domestic overseers — the courts, the ministries — are weak and often captured. In Lebanon, the **financier and the public** are the two levers most distinctive and decisive, because they can act where the captured state will not. Each is a separate front, and a project that depends on a financier bound by rules, destroys heritage on a fault line, reeks of corruption, and faces a roused public rarely survives pressure on several at once. You do not have to choose one front: the same well-built file — the breached safeguards, the endangered heritage, the seismic risk, the corruption — can go to the financier, its complaint mechanism, the international press, the anti-corruption networks, and the public at once, and each front that opens makes the others harder to close. A Lebanese campaign's power comes not from any single lever but from pressing several together, with the financier and the roused public as the two that reach furthest past the captured state.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how Lebanese and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the project **depends on a foreign financier** with rules you can invoke, whether it **destroys heritage or endangers safety** in ways the nation feels, whether it is **visibly corrupt**, whether the **public and civil society can be roused**, and whether the **occupation and international pressure** can be sustained. Where a foreign-financed, heritage-destroying, corruption-tainted project meets a roused public, Lebanon's levers are real, as Bisri showed; where a project is domestically financed and low-profile, discount the figures and think in terms of delay and exposure.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5-10%	1-3 months	low	Basis for every other step
Petitioning the financier	30-55%	months-years	low	Loan cancelled; project stranded
Direct action / occupation	25-50%	ongoing	low-moderate	Works stalled; nation roused; time bought
Heritage & seismic-safety case	30-55%	ongoing	low	Public and political cost raised
Exposing the corruption	25-50%	ongoing	low	Legitimacy stripped; allies won
Coalition & public mobilisation	30-55%	ongoing	low	The argument won
International pressure & media	35-60%	ongoing	low	The financier and world engaged
Court challenge	10-35%	years	low-moderate	Delay; record (weak, unreliable)
All steps combined (foreign-financed)	45-70%	1-3 years	low-moderate	Loan cancelled; project stopped
All steps combined (domestically financed)	15-40%	1-4 years	low-moderate	Delayed, exposed, scrutinised; record built

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Lebanon's real strengths are distinctive — the **financier and its rules, direct action, heritage and seismic safety**, the **anti-corruption cause**, and the **roused public**. Its constraints are severe and specific: the financier lever needs a **foreign loan to cancel**; the state is **captured and broken**; wins are often **defensive**; and the sectarian system resists unity.

A note on cost: petitioning the financier, documenting the heritage and the danger, and exposing the corruption cost little. An occupation costs time and stamina; a court case costs more and is unreliable. The expenditure that most changes outcomes is the patient building of a broad, cross-sectarian coalition and the case against the financier — exactly what carried Bisri from an approved, funded project to a cancelled one.

Effectiveness Visualization

SUCCESS PROBABILITY (cancelled, stopped, delayed, or exposed)

FOREIGN-FINANCED + HERITAGE/SAFETY + CORRUPTION -- a cancellable loan, a treasured valley, a roused public:

All steps combined:	45-70%
Petition the financier:	30-55%
Heritage + seismic + media:	30-60%
Occupation + corruption:	25-55%
Single step:	5-60%

DOMESTICALLY FINANCED / LOW-PROFILE -- no foreign loan to cancel, little national resonance:

All steps combined:	15-40%
Delay / exposure / record:	more achievable than a clean stop
Courts + civil society:	the weak domestic openings
Single step:	10-35%

How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Lebanon are **the financier and its rules, direct action, and the heritage-and-safety case**, amplified by the corruption exposed and the roused public. Bisri shows the ceiling: a campaign turned the World Bank against a dam the whole political class wanted. But the limits show the floor: without a foreign loan to cancel, and against a captured state, the realistic win is delay, exposure, and a record. Most Lebanese fights sit between, and the honest lesson is that the financier lever is real and distinctive — decisive against a foreign-financed project, far weaker against a domestically financed one, where the street and the exposure must carry the fight. Read the table, then, as a map of where to aim: the presence or absence of a cancellable foreign loan is the single biggest factor in a Lebanese fight, and where it exists, the financier lever and the case that feeds it deserve the bulk of a campaign's effort. Where it does not, the calculation shifts toward the occupation, the exposure of corruption, and the slow accumulation of a record, with the honest expectation of delay and scrutiny rather than a clean cancellation.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **Petitioning the financier** — Lebanon's most distinctive and decisive lever; holding a foreign lender to its own rules can cancel a project the state would never stop, as at Bisri.
2. **Direct action and the roused public** — the occupation that stalls the works and the mobilisation that rouses the nation, the force a captured state still fears.
3. **The heritage and seismic-safety case** — the threat to treasured land and heritage, and the danger of a project on a fault, that make a local fight a national cause.
4. **Exposing the corruption** — stripping the project's legitimacy and tying it to the wider anti-corruption struggle.
5. **International pressure, media, and the record** — the coverage and the documentation that reach the financier and the world, and outlast a single decision.

What Lebanese Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **The financier can be turned** — Bisri's loan was cancelled when the Bank's rules were invoked and the state failed its conditions. **Occupation buys time and attention** — camping in the valley stalled the works and roused the nation. **Heritage and safety unite** — a treasured valley and a dam on a fault rouse the public across factions. **Corruption discredits** — tying the project to the political class's rot won allies. **The captured state won't help** — the win came from outside it. The through-line: **find the financier and invoke its rules; take the site; make the heritage-and-safety case; expose the corruption; build the broad public; and press the international pressure — because in Lebanon the state will not save the valley, but the financier, the street, and the world might.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective campaign begins by finding the exact decision that governs the project — and its weakest point, which in Lebanon is often the financier. Vague opposition goes nowhere; opposition to "the dam the World Bank is funding that would drown a Bronze-Age valley and fifty heritage sites on an earthquake fault, pushed by the same corrupt class that ruined the country" is a case — the case that stopped Bisri. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. Who is financing it, and what are its rules? This is the first Lebanese question, because the **foreign financier** — the World Bank, a development bank, a donor — is bound by **safeguards, preconditions, and complaint mechanisms** you can invoke, and is often the most reachable decision-maker, as at Bisri. Identify the financier and its rules first.

2. What does it destroy or endanger? What **heritage, archaeology, and fertile land** would it take, and does it **endanger safety** — a dam on a seismic fault, a project in a hazard zone? These are the gravest harms and the arguments that rouse the nation.

3. Is it corrupt? Who pushed it, who profits, and does it fit the pattern of the political class's rent-seeking — the kind of project the 2019 uprising condemned? The corruption is both a ground and a rallying cause.

4. Can the public be roused, and the site taken? Can this become a national cause across sectarian lines, and can the **site be occupied** to stall the works and rouse the nation, as Bisri's valley was?

5. Who decides, who benefits, and who is watching? Which financier, officials, and contractors are behind it; who profits; which communities, heritage, and land are affected; and which civil-society networks, lawyers, international bodies, press, and public can be engaged. This maps your levers and your audiences at once.

A Worked Example

Suppose the state and a foreign bank propose a dam or development that would drown a heritage-rich valley on a fault, pushed by connected politicians.

Working the five questions: the **financier** — which foreign bank, under what rules and preconditions, with what complaint mechanism? The harm — **the heritage, the fertile land, the seismic danger** — the argument to rouse the nation. The **corruption** — who profits, and does it fit the pattern the uprising condemned? Can the **public be roused and the site occupied**? And the deciders are the financier and the political class, with civil society, the international community, the press, and the public as the pressure points.

Within a weekend you have moved from "we oppose the dam" to a target list: identify the financier and its rules; petition it to cancel; document the heritage and the seismic danger; expose the corruption; occupy the valley; build the broad coalition; make it national and international. That is a campaign, not a complaint — and it draws directly on how Bisri was stopped. Notice what the exercise did: it converted a diffuse despair into a short list of concrete, assignable tasks — identify and petition the financier, document the heritage and the fault, expose the corruption, occupy the valley, build the coalition — each tied to a specific lever and each of which can begin today. That is the difference the five questions make, and in Lebanon the first of them, who is financing it and under what rules, is the one that most often decides where the fight is won.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on. A financier, an international body, a journalist, the public, and even a weak court all move on evidence, not indignation — and at Bisri the documented harm to the valley, the heritage, and the safety was what turned the Bank. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Financier and the Official Record

Get the documents the decision rests on, and above all **the financier's own commitments**. Obtain the **loan agreement, the environmental and social safeguards, the preconditions, and the assessment**, and scrutinise them, because a project that **breaches the financier's own rules** — an outdated study, an unmet precondition, an absent consultation — is a project the financier can be made to drop, as Bisri's government failed the Bank's conditions. Obtain the **permits and assessments** too; they are often old or thin. Use what access-to-information exists and the financier's own disclosure. The gap between what the paper claims — a safe, consulted, beneficial project — and what the heritage, the fault, and the rules show is where cases are won. Give particular attention to the preconditions and the consultation record, because these proved decisive at Bisri: a loan that requires an ecological compensation plan, genuine public consultation, and operating arrangements before construction gives a campaign a checklist of things the state must prove it has done — and in a dysfunctional, captured system, it very often has not. Documenting each unmet precondition is documenting the ground on which the financier can be asked to walk away.

Layer 2: The Ground Truth

Document the reality the paper understates, and put the **heritage, the land, and the danger** at the centre. Record the **archaeological and historical sites, the fertile valley, the biodiversity** the project would destroy — as Bisri would have drowned a Roman temple, a church, and Bronze-Age remains across six million square metres — with the help of

archaeologists, ecologists, and heritage experts. Document the **seismic and safety danger** — a dam on an active fault, a project in a hazard zone — with the help of geologists and engineers, an argument that was central at Bisri. Photograph and date the **valley and any land clearance**. Record **testimony** from residents, landowners, and those who know the place. The heritage evidence deserves particular care, because in a land as layered as Lebanon it is both abundant and legally weighty: a documented Roman temple, a historic church, Bronze-Age remains, mapped and dated by qualified archaeologists, is not a matter of sentiment but of record, and it speaks powerfully to a financier bound by cultural-heritage safeguards and to a public that treasures its past. The same is true of the seismic evidence — a fault mapped by geologists, a reservoir-induced-earthquake risk assessed by engineers — which turns an emotional fear into a technical objection the financier must weigh.

Layer 3: The Defects, the Danger, and the Corruption

Finally, document the failures and the rot. Does the project **breach the financier's safeguards** or fail its **preconditions**, as Bisri's did? Is the **assessment old or deficient**? Does it **endanger safety** on a fault? And, distinctively in Lebanon, **is it corrupt** — pushed by connected politicians, a vehicle for rent-seeking, fitting the pattern the uprising condemned? Trace the money and the connections. Each defect, danger, and thread of corruption is a separate ground — for the petition to the financier, a court case, an international complaint, and the public campaign — and together they make a case that is hard to wave away. This is the layer that most often decides Lebanese fights, because here a project sold as safe and beneficial is revealed to breach the financier's rules, endanger a fault-line valley, destroy irreplaceable heritage, and enrich the corrupt — exactly the case that stopped Bisri.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This is the practical companion to Step 2: the specific records that decide Lebanese cases, and where to obtain them. You will not need every item; you will need the few that expose your project's financier, its danger, and its corruption.

The Financier, the Assessment, and the Paper Trail

- **The loan agreement and the financier's safeguards** — the foreign lender's environmental and social rules, its preconditions, and its complaint mechanism; the heart of a Lebanese case, as at Bisri.
- **The environmental and social assessment** — its age, quality, and whether it was disclosed; an old or thin study is a defect.
- **The permits and approvals** — how the project was authorised, and by whom.
- **The corruption trail** — the politicians and contractors behind it, the connections, the money, the pattern of rent-seeking.
- **The safety and seismic record** — the fault, the hazard, and the project's own risk assessments.

How to Get Them

Loan and safeguard documents come through the **financier's own disclosure** and the project's public filings; permits and assessments through the ministries and what access-to-information exists; the corruption trail through investigative journalists, civil-society researchers, and the public record. Much is opaque in Lebanon, so lean on **allies and publicity**: the environmental and anti-corruption civil-society networks, sympathetic experts and journalists, and international watchdogs who know how to press a financier. Move early: petitioning the financier, invoking its preconditions, and reaching it before construction and before the loan is disbursed carry far more weight than the same point made later — and the financier's own review timelines are defined.

The Ground Evidence

- **The heritage and archaeology** — the sites, ruins, and historical places the project would destroy, from archaeologists and heritage experts.
- **The land and biodiversity** — the fertile valley, the groves, the habitats, from ecologists.
- **The seismic and safety danger** — the fault, the earthquake risk, the reservoir-induced hazard, from geologists and engineers.
- **Dated, geotagged photographs and video** of the valley and any land clearance.
- **The corruption evidence** — the connections, the contracts, the pattern.
- **Testimony** — from residents, landowners, and those who know the place.

Organise It So It Persuades

Keep a **master timeline** of the loan, the preconditions, the permits, and every deadline — the spine of any petition, complaint, or campaign. Keep a **document index** so any fact can be sourced in seconds. And keep an **argument bank** (developed in a later section) that pairs each fact with what it proves, to whom. A well-ordered file is not bureaucracy; it is what lets a resident, an expert, a lawyer, a journalist, a financier's officer, an international body, and the public all see the same clear picture fast, and it guards against the campaign's own worst enemy, a claim that cannot be sourced when the state or the contractor pushes back. In a country where the financier can stop a project the state will not, the community with the better-kept file — above all the clearest evidence of the breached rules, the endangered heritage, the seismic risk, and the corruption — is very often the one that turns the financier and the nation.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION — HOW TO BUILD THE COALITION AND TAKE THE VALLEY

Evidence and law do not stop projects on their own. Organised, roused people do — and in Lebanon, where the state is captured, the coalition and the occupation are often what force the outcome. Bisri was won because a broad movement documented the harm, petitioned the financier, occupied the valley, and tied the fight to the nation's anger. A Lebanese campaign's strength is the breadth of the coalition it builds and its willingness to take and hold the site.

Phase 1: The Core and the Valley

Start with a small, committed core — five to fifteen people who will carry the work — and build the campaign around the **place and its heritage**, because a treasured valley on a fault rouses the public. Assign roles: financier liaison, documentation, heritage and safety experts, legal, media and international outreach, occupation and logistics, and coalition-building. Agree on the goal — the loan cancelled, the project stopped, the valley saved — and on what you will and will not accept.

Phase 2: The Broad, Cross-Sectarian Coalition

Then widen deliberately, and — crucially in Lebanon — **across sectarian lines**, because a project the whole political class backs can only be beaten by a public that refuses to be divided by sect. Bring in the **environmental movement** — the Lebanon Eco Movement and the country's green organisations — the **heritage and academic community** (archaeologists, historians, engineers, geologists) whose evidence moves the financier, the **anti-corruption movement** and the civil society of the 2019 uprising, the **affected landowners and residents**, and the **wider public** for whom the valley and the heritage are a shared inheritance. Reach the **international watchdogs and river-defender networks** who know how to press a financier, and the **diaspora and international press**. The Bisri campaign drew its power from exactly this breadth — greens, heritage experts, anti-corruption activists, residents, and internationals as one — which is precisely the spread a winning Lebanese campaign needs. The cross-sectarian breadth is not a nicety but a necessity, and a distinctive challenge of organising in Lebanon: the political system is built to divide the public by sect, and a project backed by the whole establishment can only be beaten by a coalition that refuses that division and speaks for the valley and the country rather than for any community. The Bisri campaign's strength was precisely that it drew Lebanese of every background around a shared valley and a shared anger at corruption, and any campaign that lets itself be reduced to one sect's grievance has already handed the establishment its easiest weapon.

A worked coalition example. Facing a foreign-financed dam on a heritage valley, the residents and greens form the base; the archaeologists and geologists document the heritage and the fault; the anti-corruption activists tie it to the political class's rot; the international watchdogs press the financier; and the wider public and diaspora carry the fight beyond the reach of the captured state. No single group could have carried it; together they cover the place, the science, the money, the financier, and the nation — the model that stopped Bisri.

Phase 3: Sustaining It

Campaigns die of burnout, not defeat — and Lebanon's crises test endurance cruelly. Meet on a rhythm. Give people concrete, finishable tasks. Mark small wins — a precondition unmet, a financier's concern raised, a wave of coverage, a strong day in the valley. Rotate the exhausting roles, especially the occupation. Keep the coalition broad and cross-sectarian, since a Lebanese campaign's power is its refusal to be split by sect or by the promise of jobs and water. And guard the unity against the state's and the contractor's efforts to divide it.

Phase 4: Taking and Holding the Site

Here is Lebanon's distinctive tactic. When the bulldozers come, **occupy the site** — camp in the valley, stall the works, and make the occupation visible, as Bisri's defenders camped for a month and tied themselves to the pines. When land clearance began in the valley, defenders came from across the country and camped there for weeks to stall the machines; later, even under the constraints of the pandemic, activists in masks and gloves entered the site and bound themselves to the pine trees. Each such act was small in itself, but together they kept the valley in the news, forced the state to confront disciplined and sympathetic opponents rather than an empty site, and raised precisely the reputational cost the financier was weighing. A peaceful, disciplined, well-documented occupation buys time, rouses the nation, draws the press and the internationals, and raises the political and reputational cost the financier weighs. It is not spectacle for its own sake; it is to demonstrate — to the financier, the state, and the world — that the community will physically defend its valley, as Bisri's defenders demonstrated until the loan was cancelled. Keep it peaceful and documented, because the financier's own rules require the state to deal peacefully with opponents, and any violence against a disciplined occupation is itself a point against the project.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES — THE FINANCIER'S RULES, THE COURTS, AND THE RECORD

Lebanese domestic law offers weak and unreliable tools, but the **financier's own rules** are a powerful legal-adjacent lever, and international and reputational pressure is real. You do not need a domestic court victory to win: invoking the financier's safeguards, filing to its complaint mechanism, exposing the breached preconditions, and pressing the international case halts a project and creates leverage, as at Bisri. Engage lawyers and civil society — but understand where the real power lies.

The Financier's Rules and Complaint Mechanism

The first and most decisive lever is the **financier's own framework**. A foreign lender like the World Bank is bound by **environmental and social safeguards**, by **preconditions to construction**, and by its own **public commitments** on climate, sustainability, and participation, and it operates an **accountability or complaint mechanism** open to affected people. Establish that the project **breaches those safeguards** or **fails those preconditions** — as Bisri's government failed to meet the Bank's conditions — file to the complaint mechanism, and hold the financier publicly to its own rules. This is Lebanon's signature lever, and it can cancel a project the state would never stop. In practice this means learning the financier's specific policies and process: which safeguard applies to heritage, which to resettlement, which to consultation; what the preconditions to construction actually require; how the complaint or accountability mechanism receives and investigates submissions; and what deadlines govern each. A campaign that speaks the financier's own language — citing the exact policy breached and the exact precondition unmet — is far harder to dismiss than one that pleads in general terms, and it works within the process by which the bank makes its decisions.

The Corruption and the Public Money

The second lever, distinctively powerful in Lebanon, is the **corruption**. A destructive project pushed by the political class is often also a **rent-seeking vehicle**, and exposing that — the connections, the contracts, the pattern of a bankrupt state borrowing for a dam the few will profit from — is both a public argument and, where documented, a matter for anti-corruption bodies and the financier's own integrity rules. Attacking the corruption strips the project's legitimacy and wins the nation.

The Courts

The third lever is the **domestic courts**. They can, in principle, review permits and decisions, but they are **slow, politically entangled, and unreliable**, so treat a court challenge as one front among several — useful for delay, disclosure, and the record, but rarely the decisive blow. In Lebanon, the financier and the street usually move a project before the courts do. This is not a counsel to ignore the courts entirely; a well-chosen case can buy time, force documents into the open, and add to the record the financier and the press draw on. It is a counsel about proportion: do not stake the campaign on a domestic judicial victory that the system is unlikely to deliver or to enforce, when the same effort aimed at the financier and the public is far more likely to bear fruit.

International and Reputational Pressure

Finally, the **international framework**. Lebanon is watched by the **international community, the diaspora, and the global press**, and a financier funding a destructive, corrupt project on a fault line is vulnerable to reputational pressure

and to the **river-defender and watchdog networks** that campaign against exactly such projects. Bring that pressure to bear, as the Bisri campaign did, reaching the world beyond the captured state. The diaspora is a particular asset here: Lebanese communities abroad are large, connected, and able to reach the media, the parliaments, and sometimes the financiers of the countries they live in, extending a local campaign's reach far past what its numbers at home would suggest. Enlisting them, and the international river-defender and bank-watchdog networks, turns a valley's fight into an international one the financier cannot quietly ignore.

Where to Turn and With Whom

Financier complaints go to the **lender's accountability mechanism**; corruption to the **anti-corruption bodies and the press**; permits and decisions to the **courts**, weakly. Get help early: Lebanon's environmental lawyers, the Lebanon Eco Movement and green organisations, the anti-corruption networks, and international watchdogs know the financier's rules, the complaint mechanisms, the international channels, and the strongest ground. Help engaged while the loan is live and before construction is worth far more than help sought after the doors have closed — and in Lebanon, the strongest strategy marries the **financier's rules** to the **exposure of the corruption** and the **occupation of the site**.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades a financier, an international body, a journalist, the public, and a court in different ways. Learning to translate your evidence for each audience is what lets a community reach every lever at once.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that a World-Bank-funded dam would drown a Bronze-Age valley and fifty heritage sites on an active seismic fault, and its government sponsor has not met the Bank's own preconditions. That one fact becomes:

- **A financier argument:** the project breaches your safeguards and fails your preconditions; cancel it — the case that stopped Bisri.
- **A heritage-and-safety argument (to the public):** they would drown a Roman temple and our valley, on an earthquake fault — the argument that rouses the nation.
- **An anti-corruption argument:** a bankrupt state borrowing millions for a dam the political class will profit from — the case that ties it to the uprising.
- **An international argument:** a development bank funding a destructive, corrupt, dangerous project — a reputational case the world and the river-defender networks will take up.
- **A legal argument:** the assessment is old and deficient, the preconditions unmet, the process improper — grounds for a complaint and, weakly, a court.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and in Lebanon the arguments that most often decide things are the **financier** one, because it can cancel the project, and the **heritage-safety-and-corruption** one, because it rouses the nation. Keep the arguments anchored to the same documented facts, so a claim made to a reporter can be backed in the financier's own file and a claim made to the Bank can be proven by the archaeologists and geologists; consistency across audiences is itself persuasive.

Match the Argument to the Audience

The financier wants the harm framed precisely against its own rules — the breached safeguard, the unmet precondition, the deficient assessment, the reputational risk — with the science and the timeline that prove it.

International bodies and the diaspora respond to the heritage, the danger, the corruption, and the breach of the financier's public commitments.

Journalists need a specific, verified, visual story with a hook: a named valley and its ruins, a fault line, a corrupt political sponsor, and the David-and-Goliath of citizens against the establishment and the Bank.

The public, across sects, needs the argument simple, true, and rousing: they would drown our heritage on a fault, to enrich the corrupt — the case that carried Bisri.

The coalition itself needs to see the fight is winnable and broad, so it holds together through the occupation and the

long petition to the financier.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY — HOW PRESS COVERAGE SHIFTS OUTCOMES

Media is not vanity; it is a lever. Coverage raises the political and reputational cost of a project, reaches the financier and the international community, and rouses the nation. Bisri was, in the end, won partly in the public eye: the coverage of a treasured valley, its heritage, and its fault line, and of a bankrupt state borrowing for a corrupt dam, made the project politically toxic and helped move the Bank.

Build the Story

Reporters and the public need specifics: a named place and stake, a documented threat, and a live decision. "A project threatens the environment" is not a story; "a World-Bank-funded dam would drown a Roman temple and a Bronze-Age valley on an earthquake fault, pushed by the same class that bankrupted the country" is. Lead with your strongest verified facts — the heritage, the seismic danger, the corruption — and offer a human and expert voice: a resident, an archaeologist, a geologist. In Lebanon the story of a treasured valley and its heritage against a corrupt establishment and its foreign loan is uniquely powerful.

Reach the Right Outlets

Work outward in rings. **Local and community voices** first — the affected valley. Then the **national outlets** — Lebanon's press and broadcasters — which carry the story to the whole country. Then, crucially, the **international and diaspora rings** — the global press, the river-defender and watchdog networks, and the Lebanese abroad — which bring reputational pressure on the financier and reach the world beyond the captured state, as they did over Bisri. Feed each ring what it needs, and let coverage in one pull in the next. The **international and financier-facing rings are especially decisive** in Lebanon, because the financier answers to a reputation the Lebanese state does not. This is why the diaspora and the global press matter more here than they might elsewhere: a story that a development bank is funding the drowning of a Bronze-Age valley on a fault line, to enrich a bankrupt state's political class, is exactly the kind of reputational embarrassment a bank prefers to avoid, and the river-defender and watchdog networks abroad know how to place and amplify it. The Bisri campaign's reach beyond Lebanon's borders was not a supplement to the fight; it was a main front of it.

Sustain It, and Keep It True

A single article changes little; a drumbeat changes decisions. Plan a sequence — the heritage, the fault, the corruption, the financier's unmet conditions, the occupation — so there is always a next hook, and build your own clear record so the story reaches the public and endures. Keep messaging disciplined, accurate, and consistent; in a polarised country, one exaggeration handed to the establishment can cost credibility, especially with the financier and the internationals. Verified, specific, heritage-and-danger-and-corruption-centred, and relentless — that is the coverage that shifts outcomes here, and that helped turn a nation, the world, and a bank against the drowning of Bisri.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you object, demand, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act — above all the financier, which lies beyond the captured state's reach. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything, and send important items so that receipt is provable. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the financier's rules, the heritage, the danger, and the corruption.

8A. Petition / Letter to the Financier

To: the World Bank / development bank / donor funding the project **Subject:** Cancel [project] — it breaches your safeguards and fails your preconditions

We, the people of [place] and the [campaign], call on you to **cancel** your financing of [project] at [location]. It breaches your environmental and social safeguards and fails your preconditions to construction: [the deficient assessment / the

unmet ecological plan / the absent consultation]. It would destroy [the heritage and fertile land] and endanger safety [on an active fault], and it is tainted by corruption. We attach our evidence, and we hold you to your own commitments on climate, sustainability, and participation, as the people of Bisri held you.

8B. Complaint to the Financier's Accountability Mechanism

To: the [Inspection Panel / accountability / complaint mechanism] of [financier] **Subject:** Complaint regarding [project], [loan reference]

We are people affected by [project], financed by [lender]. We submit that the project breaches your policies on [environment / heritage / consultation / safety] and that the preconditions have not been met. The harms: [heritage destroyed, fault-line danger, absent consultation]. We request that you investigate and that financing be **suspended and cancelled**, per your own rules.

8C. Demand to the Government / Ministry

To: the relevant ministry / the cabinet **Subject:** Halt [project] at [location]

We, the community of [place], demand that [project] be **halted**. It would destroy [heritage and land] on [a seismic fault], it fails the financier's preconditions, and it serves [corrupt interests] while the country is bankrupt. We attach our evidence and the experts' warnings, and the nation stands behind this demand.

8D. Instructing a Lawyer / Civil-Society Organisation

To: an environmental lawyer / the Lebanon Eco Movement / an anti-corruption network **Subject:** [Project] — the financier's rules, the corruption, and the law

We believe [project] is unlawful, dangerous, and corrupt because [it breaches the financier's safeguards / endangers a fault-line valley / enriches the connected]. We attach the loan and safeguard documents, the assessment, our heritage and seismic evidence, and the corruption trail, and seek advice on **petitioning the financier and its complaint mechanism, exposing the corruption, an international campaign, and any court challenge**. Please advise on the strongest ground and the deadlines.

8E. Letter to a Contractor / Investor

To: [the contractor / investor / parent company] **Subject:** [Project] — legal, reputational, and financing risk

We write regarding your role in [project] at [location]. The project [one-line stake — e.g. "would drown a Bronze-Age valley and fifty heritage sites on an earthquake fault"], breaches the financier's safeguards, and is tainted by corruption. We remind you that the Bisri dam's financing was cancelled on exactly such grounds. We ask you to weigh the legal, reputational, and financing risk, and we are glad to share our evidence.

8F. Letter to an International Watchdog / River-Defender Network

To: [the international watchdog / Bankwatch-type network / river-defenders] **Subject:** [Project] in Lebanon — please help us press the financier

We are fighting [project] in [place], funded by [lender], which would destroy [heritage and land] on [a fault] and is tainted by corruption. We ask for your help pressing the financier to honour its own safeguards and cancel the loan, as happened with Bisri. We attach our evidence and can connect you with residents and experts.

8G. Email to a Reporter (National or International)

To: [journalist] **Subject:** Story tip: [specific finding] — [the valley / the heritage]

I follow your coverage of [beat]. We have something your readers should know, with a clear hook: [documents and expert evidence] show [quantified finding — e.g. "a World-Bank-funded dam would drown a Roman temple and a Bronze-Age valley on an active fault"], with [a decision] due [date]. It echoes how Bisri was stopped. I can share the full file and connect you with residents and an archaeologist. Could we talk this week?

8H. Petition / Public Statement

To: the public and the financier **Subject:** Save [the valley] from [project]

We call on the people of Lebanon and the world to save [the valley and its heritage] from [project], which would [one-line harm] on [a fault], to enrich the corrupt while the country is bankrupt. Sign, share, and stand with us, as the people stood for Bisri — and we call on [the financier] to honour its own rules and cancel the loan.

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable, and log every one in your timeline — the record of a petition to the financier, a complaint to its mechanism, or a demand to the ministry is itself evidence, and exactly what the financier, the international bodies, and the press will heed. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the financier's rules, the heritage, the danger, and the corruption; attach your evidence; and route them, where you can, through the coalition, the green and anti-corruption networks, international watchdogs, your lawyers, and the press. The reply, or the decision, becomes part of your record, and in Lebanon that record feeds the levers that matter most: the financier's rules, the corruption exposed, the heritage-and-safety case, and the international pressure.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can run a long campaign. With a few hours a week you can still do real damage to a bad project. In rough order of impact for the effort:

- 1. Find the financier and petition it.** In Lebanon, the foreign financier is often the reachable decision-maker. Identify it, invoke its safeguards and preconditions, and petition it to cancel (8A) — the lever that stopped Bisri.
- 2. Make the heritage-and-safety case.** The threat to a treasured, heritage-rich valley, and the danger of a project on a fault, rouse the nation. State it plainly and carry it wide (8G, 8H).
- 3. Expose the corruption.** Tie the project to the political class's rent-seeking and the wider anti-corruption cause (8G).
- 4. File to the financier's complaint mechanism.** A formal complaint (8B) invokes the financier's own rules and forces a review.
- 5. Reach international watchdogs.** The river-defender and watchdog networks (8F) know how to press a financier, and reach the world beyond the captured state.
- 6. Take the site if the works begin.** A peaceful, documented occupation (Step 3) stalls the works and rouses the nation.
- 7. Build the coalition and reach the press.** The greens, the heritage experts, the anti-corruption activists (8D), and a vivid national and international story (8G).

Do only the first three and you will have petitioned the financier, made the heritage-and-safety case, and exposed the corruption — the exact foundation on which Bisri was stopped. Then come back and read the rest. Even the shortest version has a spine: find the financier and petition it, make the heritage-and-safety case, expose the corruption. Those three moves are exactly the ones that, done early, put the decisive Lebanese levers into play — the foreign lender that can cancel a project the state will not, the treasured heritage and the fault-line danger that rouse the nation, and the corruption that strips the project's legitimacy — and they are within reach of a handful of determined people with a well-built file and the will to send it to Washington and to the press.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Lebanon's system is not merely tilted; in large part it is captured and broken, and you must understand exactly how, so you neither waste effort on the state nor miss the levers that still work.

Where the Tilt Shows

The tilt here is severe and distinctive. The **state is captured** by a sectarian political class that treats projects as spoils, so the government, the ministries, and often the courts are the proponent's allies, not yours. **Enforcement is weak**, so even a legal win or a permit condition may not be honoured. The country is **bankrupt and in crisis**, which the establishment

uses to justify borrowing for projects the few will profit from. And the **sectarian system** resists the cross-sectarian unity a campaign needs, while offering the establishment endless ways to divide it. Where these tilts bite — which is nearly everywhere in the state — a lever aimed at the domestic system gives little. The answer is to aim elsewhere.

What Still Works — And Some Is Distinctive

The decisive point is that even in a captured state, real and distinctive levers remain — precisely because they lie outside it.

The financier still answers to its own rules. A foreign lender is bound by safeguards and reputations the Lebanese state is not, and can be made to cancel a project, as at Bisri. This is the single most important thing to understand about fighting in a captured state: the lever you need is not inside the system that has been captured, so do not exhaust yourself trying to move it there. Aim at the financier, whose rules are real and whose reputation is vulnerable, and you are pushing on a door that can actually open.

The site can still be taken. A peaceful occupation stalls the works and rouses the nation, whatever the state does.

The heritage and the fault still rouse. A threat to treasured land and heritage, and a danger on a fault, unite the public across sects.

The corruption still discredits. Exposing the rot strips the project's legitimacy and ties it to the cause the nation already embraces.

The world and the record still matter. International pressure and a documented record reach beyond the captured state and outlast a single decision.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for Lebanon is unusual and sobering: the state will rarely help you, and some fights are lost to its capture and collapse — but the levers that lie outside the state are real and, in the Bisri case, decisive. The financier's rules, the occupation, the heritage-and-safety case, the corruption exposed, and the international pressure give a community power the captured state cannot take away. So diagnose your fight honestly: find the **financier** and hold it to its rules; **take the site**; make the **heritage-and-safety case**; **expose the corruption**; reach the **world**; and where a foreign financier or an outright stop is out of reach, pursue the delay, the exposure, and the record that are the realistic gains against a captured state. Do not waste your strength on the ministries that serve the project; spend it where it bites.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

In Lebanon, corruption is not an occasional aggravating factor; it is the system, and this section is therefore central. When a destructive project is, at bottom, a rent-seeking vehicle for the political class — a bankrupt state borrowing for a dam a few will profit from — your strategy is built around exposing and going around the capture from the start.

How to Tell

Look for the signatures of capture, which here are the norm. A project **pushed by connected politicians** and their contractors; **approved despite the harm** and the cost; a **bankrupt state borrowing** for a mega-project of doubtful need; a pattern of **similar projects** enriching the same class; and the **need — water, power — invoked to justify** what mainly serves the few. Trace the money and the connections: who pushed it, who profits, who built the last one. In Lebanon, a destructive mega-project is very often a corruption vehicle first and a development project second, as critics said of the dam-building programme Bisri belonged to.

Who Can Be Captured — and Who Is Harder

Be clear-eyed about where capture reaches — which in Lebanon is far. **The political class, the ministries, much of the state, and often the courts** are captured. But some forces are far harder to capture, and they are your targets: the **foreign financier**, bound by its own rules and reputation; the **international community, watchdogs, and press**; the **independent experts** — the archaeologists, geologists, engineers; the **anti-corruption civil society** of the uprising; and the **mobilised public**, which at Bisri stopped the establishment. Capture thrives inside the state; your task is to lift the matter outside it — to the financier, the world, the experts, and the street.

What to Do

Do not rely on the captured state. Instead, **document the corruption precisely** — the connections, the contracts, the pattern, the bankrupt state's borrowing — and take it, with the harm and the danger, to the forces beyond the capture: the **financier** and its integrity and safeguard rules; the **international community, watchdogs, and press**; the **anti-corruption bodies** where any function; and the **public**, tying the project to the wider cause the nation already fights for. Pair the exposure with the heritage-and-safety case and the financier's breached rules, so the corruption and the harm surface together. In Lebanon, exposing the corruption is not a side-argument; it is often the heart of the campaign, because a project revealed as a corrupt vehicle for a bankrupt state's political class loses the nation, the world, and — as at Bisri — the financier. There is a strategic reason to lead with the corruption in Lebanon that does not apply everywhere: because the public already believes, with good reason, that the political class steals, a credible, documented showing that a given project is one more such theft slots into a story the nation is primed to accept and act on, and it recruits the energy of the wider anti-corruption movement to a specific, winnable fight. The corruption is not merely an aggravating detail; it is often the frame that makes the whole campaign legible and mobilising.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The five steps win when they run together. Here is how they fit across the life of a fight — which in Lebanon turns on the financier, the occupation, and the exposure of corruption.

Early (Weeks 0-8): The Financier, the Heritage, the Corruption

Pin down the project, its **financier and that financier's rules** (Step 1), and what it destroys — the **heritage, the land, the fault** (Step 1). Build the **core and the cross-sectarian coalition** (Step 3). Move at once on what is decisive: **petition the financier** and invoke its preconditions (8A); **make the heritage-and-safety case** (8G, 8H); **expose the corruption** (8G); and **file to the financier's complaint mechanism** (8B). Begin the **heritage, seismic, and corruption documentation** (Step 2). Reach the **green and anti-corruption networks, international watchdogs, and a lawyer** early (8D, 8F). This phase lays the foundation, and in Lebanon the petition to the financier and the exposure begun here are what ultimately win.

Middle (Months 2-24): Escalate on Every Front

Broaden the coalition across sects and to the diaspora (Step 3). Turn your evidence into arguments for each audience (Turning Evidence). Escalate as the facts warrant — the **financier pressed** toward suspension and cancellation, the **complaint** advanced, the **international pressure** built, and, if the works begin, the **occupation** (Step 3, Step 4). Reach the **contractors and investors** (8E). Build the media drumbeat from local to national to international (Step 5). Each front feeds the others. Do the time-critical things first — every objection and complaint within its window, the financier reached before disbursement and construction — because those chances do not return. And sequence the rest to press the financier at the moments it is most exposed: the letter timed to a board decision or a review, the complaint filed while the preconditions are visibly unmet, the international coverage built toward a deadline the bank has set itself. At Bisri the decisive window was the stretch between the partial suspension and the final deadline, when the government's failure to meet the conditions became undeniable; recognising and pressing such a window is often what converts a long campaign into a cancellation.

Later (Months 6-48+): The Cancellation, and Vigilance

Sustain the coalition through Lebanon's crises; keep the record and the coverage alive. Pursue what is achievable — the loan **cancelled, the project stopped, the valley saved** — and, against a domestically financed project, the **delay, exposure, and record** that are the realistic gains. And stay vigilant, because a captured state may revive a project under a new guise or financier, and the underlying need — water, power — will be invoked again, so be ready with the alternatives. Judge success honestly. Sometimes it is a loan cancelled and a valley saved, as at Bisri. Sometimes it is a project delayed and exposed while the coalition holds. Both are victories worth the fight. And a cancellation, where it comes, is worth guarding: a captured state that lost a project once may try to revive it under a new name, a new financier, or a new justification when the attention has faded, so the coalition that won should keep a watch and a readiness to move again, as the underlying pressures that produced the project in the first place rarely disappear.

The Shape of a Campaign

WEEKS 0-8 Identify + petition the financier | Heritage-and-safety case | Expose the corruption | File the complaint
MONTHS 2-24 Broaden the coalition | Arguments | Press the financier + complaint + international + (occupation) | Contractors | M
MONTHS 6-48+ The cancellation | Save the valley / delay / expose | Guard against a revival

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Lebanon gives communities a genuinely powerful — and, because the state is so broken, distinctive — set of tools, and the honest measure of this guide is how squarely it faces both their strength and their limits.

The strengths are real and distinctive. The **financier and its rules** can cancel a project the captured state would never stop, as the World Bank cancelled Bisri. **Direct action** — the occupation of the valley — stalls the works and rouses the nation. The **heritage and the seismic danger** make a threat to a treasured, fault-line valley a national cause. **Exposing the corruption** strips a project's legitimacy and ties it to the struggle the nation already fights. And **international pressure and a documented record** reach beyond the captured state. These are the levers that let the people of Bisri stop a mega-dam the whole political class wanted.

The limits are just as real, and this guide names them because in Lebanon they are severe. The financier lever needs a **foreign loan to cancel**, and a state that fails its conditions. The **state is captured, sectarian, and broke**, so domestic institutions rarely help and enforcement is weak. The win is often **defensive**, stopping a project without meeting the need it claimed to serve. And the wider uprising did not remake the system. No guide should pretend these away; in Lebanon, the art is to fight outside a state that will not help you.

So the realistic promise is this: **find the financier and hold it to its rules; take the site; make the heritage-and-safety case; expose the corruption; reach the world; and pursue delay and exposure where a clean stop is out of reach — running all of it together.** Do that, and against a foreign-financed, heritage-destroying, corruption-tainted project, you can have the loan cancelled and the valley saved, as at Bisri; against a domestically financed one, you can delay, expose, and scrutinise it while the coalition holds. Do it as the people of Bisri did — a broad, cross-sectarian coalition of greens, heritage experts, anti-corruption activists, residents, and internationals that petitioned the Bank, occupied the valley, exposed the corruption, and saved a Bronze-Age treasure from a corrupt dam.

A last word on fighting a captured state. Lebanon's lesson is that when your own government cannot be trusted to protect a valley, the levers that can are the ones outside it — the financier bound by its rules, the world watching, the experts, the corruption laid bare, and the people in the valley itself. The establishment counts on your despair, on the sectarian divisions, on the crisis that exhausts you, and on the belief that nothing can be stopped in a broken state. Its advantage is its capture of the state. That capture is real and should not be underestimated — it means the ministries, the permits, and often the courts will move against you, and that the ordinary domestic routes a community elsewhere might rely on are largely closed. But capture of the state is not capture of the financier, the international press, the independent experts, or the public, and it is on that ground, outside the captured state, that Lebanese campaigns are won. Yours is a financier that answers to rules the state ignores, a heritage the whole nation treasures, a danger no one can dismiss, a corruption everyone can see, and a public that, at Bisri, proved the establishment can be beaten. Play to that. Keep the file and the evidence, keep the heritage and the fault and the corruption at the centre, keep the coalition broad and cross-sectarian, petition the financier, take the valley, and treat every letter to the Bank, every complaint, every day in the valley, and every exposure of the rot as a brick in a wall no corrupt establishment can climb.

The tools are here, and Lebanon itself proved them: a broad coalition of citizens, unwilling to let a corrupt class drown a heritage valley on a fault with a foreign loan, turned the World Bank against the dam and saved the Bisri Valley, its ruins, its groves, and its people, from a project the entire establishment had wanted built. What decides the outcome, in the end, is method, endurance, and a public that defends its heritage and refuses the corruption — and those you supply, even against a captured state, by aiming past it at the financier, the world, and the valley itself. Begin today, begin with the financier and its rules, the heritage and the fault beneath it, and the corruption that drives the project, and build from there. Communities before you have cancelled, stopped, and overturned what the whole establishment wanted — a loan cancelled, a valley of Bronze-Age ruins and pine and citrus saved, a corrupt dam defeated by the people who would have lost the most. They did it without a functioning state on their side, against the whole political class, in the middle of an economic collapse and a pandemic, by refusing to accept that a captured system had the last word — and that refusal, more than any single tactic, is the thing to carry into your own fight. What was won at Bisri can be won again. So can yours.